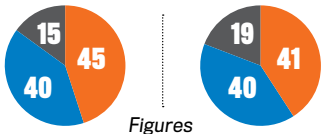
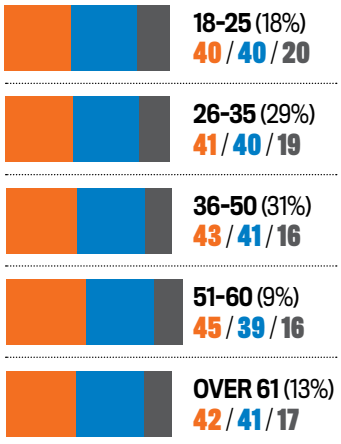
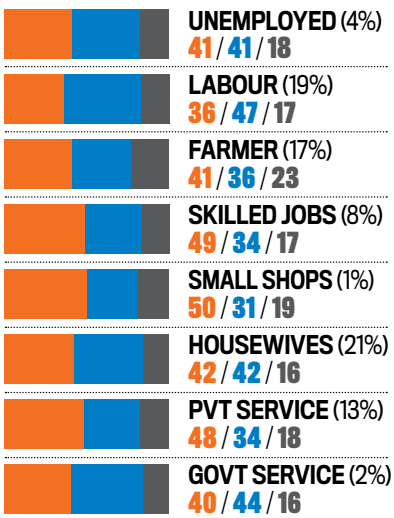
GEOGRAPHY

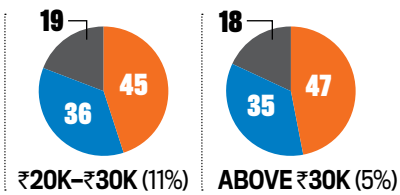


AGE GROUPS



OCCUPATION





Figures in percentage;
Figures in () indicate share in total population

one more than the Congress's tally of 10.

However, while the victory is theirs, did the BJP do as well as it expected? A win in 115 of the 199 seats that went to the polls is way lower than the 155 the party's state unit had been promising to the high command. (Election to one seat—Karanpur—was adjourned after the death of a candidate.) In fact, this is the BJP's worst performance in the previous three elections that it fought when in Opposition. It won 163 of the 200 seats in 2013 and 120 in 2003. Cornering the votes of the smaller parties, the BJP did manage to take its vote share to 41.69 per cent from 2018's 38.77 per cent. But compare that to Madhya Pradesh (48.55 per cent) and Chhattisgarh (46.37 per cent), where its win looked less likely, the BJP could do with some introspection in Rajasthan.

For, even as the party managed to wrest seven of the 19 seats where it suffered successive defeats in the past three elections, it lost 10 of the 29 'safest' seats that it had won in those three elections. The party is especially left stunned by its loss in two seats—Taranagar and Amber. In Taranagar, seven-time MLA and leader of the Opposition (LoP) Rajendra Rathore was in the fray, having shifted his base from Churu. The BJP's Rajput face, he was among the party's myriad CM hopefuls. So was deputy LoP and former state BJP chief Satish Poonia, who failed to retain his Amber seat. What went against both the leaders apparently was disillusionment among voters and the party cadre, say those in the know, due to their consistent agenda to cut down Raje and her loyalists to size.

GEHLOT'S CRITICS SAY HIS RELIANCE ON OLD FACES COST CONGRESS THE ELECTION. THE OUTGOING CM SAYS HE HAD NO OPTION FOR WANT OF WINNING CANDIDATES

It is the Congress, though, that needs the greater introspection. Gehlot did put up a strong fight, winning 69 seats with a 39.53 per cent vote share, but he has to bear the onus of the party's defeat. In fact, 17 of his 30 ministers lost. Critics blame it on his reliance on old faces, a move that backfired. Gehlot claims he had no other option for want of winning candidates, a stand he had taken in 2003 and 2013 as well. But only 37 per cent of the sitting Congress MLAs who were given tickets managed to win. The score on the BJP side, by comparison, was 67 per cent of such candidates. But then, the Congress did not fare well with freshers either. Only 10, or 23 per cent, of the 43 new faces that it fielded won, as compared to 18, or 46 per cent, of the BJP's 39 debutants. Then, of course, there was Gehlot's long-running feud with his former deputy Sachin Pilot, who was pulled into the campaign much too late. The Gujjar disenchantment over the treatment meted out to Pilot—a prominent community leader—was visible in a marginal shift of votes to the BJP.

The outgoing Gehlot government leaves enough challenges for its successor, the Rs 5 lakh crore debt the biggest among them. It will not only make it hard for the BJP to carry on with the existing populist schemes but also to keep its poll promise of reducing VAT on fuel and doubling the annual assistance to farmers to Rs 12,000. But first, it has to overcome another challenge. Of choosing the chief minister. While the Raje camp claims the support of 70 MLAs, Shekhawat's asserts the backing of some 20. Add to that other CM hopefuls, and the final choice is bound to raise more than a few hackles. Going by the assembly poll results, the Modi magic will perhaps see the party through in the Lok Sabha election. But internal rifts could very well spoil the BJP's plan to register a third consecutive clean sweep in Rajasthan. ■